Unit 2: Writing a formal proposal

Formal proposals are written mainly to set forth a problem (or problems), one or more solutions to the problem(s), and what should happen in the future—either before the solutions are or can be implemented, or after they are implemented. In this unit, you will write a formal proposal that suggests **two solutions for a single problem**.

Formal proposals are texts that use formal language (e.g. the full forms of words are used, such as *will not* instead of *won't*; transition signals like *furthermore* are used; slang terms are not used, the second person (*you*) is avoided as much as possible, etc.). They are meant to be clear and logical. The reader should be able to follow the writer as he/she moves from idea to idea.

The main sections of most formal proposals are:

1. **Introduction**: This is the first section of a formal proposal. It should point out the problem it will focus on to the reader and should tell the reader in a straightforward way what the proposal is trying to do about that problem. Note the verb-noun combinations used in each example. What verb form is used after "to" and what verb form is used after "for"?

A. This proposal recommends measures to improve e-scooter safety.
B. This proposal puts forth suggestions for promoting e-scooter use among Thai university students and for increasing helmet use while using e-scooters.
C. The aims of this proposal are to recommend ways to promote e-scooter use and to suggest methods of improving e-scooter safety.

2. **Current situation**: This section gives a brief overview of what has led to the problem. This section should be clear and logical, with appropriate causes, results, and examples given. Note how the current situation is explained in each example. Why have the authors chosen to use those verb tenses?

A. In the past few years, e-scooters have become a popular form of transportation among Thai university students. However, many university students ignore traffic laws when they are on e-scooters. As a result, they get into accidents and receive injuries.
B. Nowadays, more Thai university students are using e-scooters, but they are using them recklessly. Their reckless use of e-scooters may result in accidents and injuries. For example, they may crash into trees or motorcyclists.
C. In recent years, e-scooter use has greatly increased among Thai university students. However, they often do not use helmets on e-scooters. Their lack of helmets contributes to a greater risk of injury if they have an accident.

3. **Proposed solutions**: In this section, the writer gives the reader one or several solutions to the problem he/she has talked about in the previous section. The solutions should be

introduced briefly with one or two opening sentences. Note the use of punctuation in the following examples.

A. The situation would be greatly improved with these measures:
B. There are two possible solutions to this problem, which are:
C. This problem can be solved in the following ways:
D. The situation would be greatly improved through the following two measures.
E. There are two possible solutions to this problem.
F. This problem can be solved in two ways.

The solutions that are given can be independent solutions or connected ones. Look at the following examples and determine which solutions are connected and which solution is an independent one. Also note how the solutions are presented. Are they complete sentences or phrases?

A. Putting up posters to promote e-scooter safety. Posters can be put up in areas where many university students park their e-scooters, such as the library and cafeteria. The posters should go over the risks of using e-scooters recklessly. In addition, they can show ways to safely use e-scooters in different situations. For instance, the posters can show how to use an e-scooter when it is raining.
B. Asking professionals to give talks about e-scooter safety. Different professionals such as medical doctors and police officers can give talks to university students about how to use e-scooters safely. The doctors can warn students about accidents while riding e-scooters, while the police officers can advise them about traffic laws. The talks can be advertised on the posters that promote e-scooter safety. In addition, students can register for the talks by scanning a QR code on the posters that promote e-scooter safety.
C. The development of a rewards app. A mobile app can be developed to reward university students who consistently wear helmets when they use their e-scooters. To collect points, they must upload a selfie in a helmet each day. When they have a certain number of points, they can win prizes from the university, such as cloth bags.

As you can see, Solutions A and B are connected. The advertisement and registration for the talks in solution B are presented on the posters in solution A. Solution C is an independent solution. Remember that the suggested solutions need to be possible within the given situation. It may be a good solution to attach cameras to helmets that e-scooter users wear and constantly watch them to make sure they are safe, but that would be both costly and unethical.

Also note that the solutions in the examples are not written as complete sentences, but they still have periods/full stops at the end. You can choose to write solutions as either phrases or complete sentences. However, all of your solutions should be in the same format (all phrases or all sentences).

- *Phrase*: Asking professionals to give talks about e-scooter safety. / *Sentence*: Professionals can be asked to give talks about e-scooter safety.
- *Phrase*: The development of a rewards app. / *Sentence*: The development of a rewards app should be carried out.

It is also possible to combine the opening sentence with the solutions. Remember to keep the same format for all the solutions (e.g. if the first one is a noun, the others should be nouns, etc.). Note the following examples.

A. The situation would be improved through the development of a rewards app, the distribution of safety pamphlets, and the donation of safety gear.
B. This problem could be solved by developing a rewards app, distributing safety pamphlets, and donating safety gear.
C. Two possible solutions for this problem are to develop a rewards app and to distribute safety pamphlets.

4. **Expected outcomes and benefits**: This section tells the reader what should happen after the solutions are implemented. The reader should see how the situation will change and/or what positive things will happen. Note the ways the verbs are used in the following outcomes and benefits.

A. These measures should lead to greater awareness of traffic laws among university students who use e-scooters. Consequently, e-scooter users will likely obey more traffic laws.
B. All of these measures will likely result in increased wearing of helmets among e-scooter users.
C. If the above measures are implemented, the number of e-scooter accidents and injuries will probably fall.

5. **Recommended next steps**: In this section, the next steps that are needed to implement the solutions are presented. These could be challenges that need to be addressed before the solutions will work or things that just need to be done to prepare for the solutions. Note the verbs used in this section.

A. Before these measures can be implemented, university students' awareness of traffic laws should be investigated.
B. Before proceeding further, a survey of helmet use among university students who use e-scooters will be carried out and the need for other safety gear should be determined.
C. The number of accidents that occur among university students who use e-scooters will be determined before the proposed measures are implemented.

Exercise 1. Read the following proposal and determine which introduction should be added to it.

A. This proposal suggests ways to improve elderly people's literacy.
B. This proposal puts forth methods of evaluating the literacy of elderly people.
C. This proposal recommends methods to enhance the digital literacy of elderly people.
D. This proposal advances ways of determining elderly people's digital literacy in the modern world.

In the modern world, it is important to have strong digital literacy. Digital literacy is the ability to capably and safely use technology. Many older Thai people have poor digital literacy. They often have trouble using technology because they are not familiar with it or because it makes them anxious. For example, they may not be able to book a doctor's appointment online or they may be deceived by a fake website. Consequently, their access to essential services and opportunities may be hindered.

The situation would be greatly improved through the following two measures.

The development of digital literacy training programs specifically designed for elderly individuals. These programs would provide older Thai people with the skills that are necessary to use technological devices and the internet, thus boosting their abilities and their confidence. For instance, an older man can learn how to use a device with GPS and travel around by himself without the fear of getting lost.

The creation of a 24-hour technology support call center. This would give elderly Thais a way to get immediate assistance if they have a technological question or problem. As a consequence, they never have to worry if they have an issue with technology. Therefore, their anxiety when they use technology can be reduced.

The above measures will lead to several benefits for Thai senior citizens. First and foremost, they will be able to independently and confidently access online information and services. As a result, their lives can be more convenient. For example, they can do online banking instead of going to a physical bank. Furthermore, they can stay connected to their friends and family with digital communication tools. This communication will in turn reduce their loneliness and boredom.

As a next step, a consultation with authorities and educational institutions in each Thai province about personnel and costs of implementing the above proposed measures should be carried out. Additionally, it is recommended that elderly Thai citizens review every measure to determine if they are effective. (*332 words*)

Exercise 2. Reread the proposal and answer the following questions.

1. What is the problem that this proposal suggests solutions for?

2. What are the solutions? Are they written as sentences or phrases?

3. What is the function of each of the following sets of linking words taken from the proposal? The first set has been labeled for you.

A. Linking words that **show cause and effect/result**	
As a consequence, As a result, Consequently, Therefore,	because thus
B. Linking words _____ For example, For instance,	
C. Linking words _____ Additionally, Furthermore,	
D. Linking words _____ As a next step, First and foremost,	